Primary Persona: Cara

Description / Bio:



Cara is a VUW student majoring in Computer Science and Earth Science who runs most of her group work through tools VUW does not provide. Her last project was a Godot game in a group of 5 or 6, organised through a class Discord. Only GitLab came from university; Discord, Miro and YouTube covered the rest. She picks up the slack when groupmates disappear, and is happy to use many tools as long as each does its job. What she wants from her uni tools is consistency and some integration between them. Cara is the primary persona because her interview covers the whole group project life cycle from formation to submission, she is a direct user of every tool involved, and her main pain point, inconsistency, spans every group project she has done, not just one course.

Quote:

"It feels like nothing is consistent, and the current tools barely do what they're supposed to while making it as complicated as possible."

Goals:

End goals:

- **C1.** Find her group, its page and its members' details quickly, without a different process for every course.
- **C2.** See who is doing what in one place, without checking GitLab and then asking on Discord.
- **C3.** Notice early when a teammate is behind, so the group is not left covering for them at the last minute.
- **C4.** Submit the whole project in one place, including external items such as a demo video.
- **C5.** Get help from a tutor or lecturer without leaving the group workspace.

Experience goals:

- Feel the workload is shared fairly and she is not the one picking up the slack.
- Feel confident the tools will keep working, especially on deadline day.
- Feel in the loop at every stage of the project.

Life goal:

- Become a strong computer science developer who works well with multiple tools in group settings.

Needs:

- **One group page that works the same in every course (C1),** listing members, contact details and a clear way to create, join or view a group. This replaces a setup that was "different for every group project" and a page that was hard to find, and follows consistency and standards (Nielsen, 1994).
- **Contribution overview per member (C2, C3)** showing commits, issues and last activity next to the task list, so the group does not have to dig through commit history to learn that someone has contributed nothing. This follows visibility of system status (Nielsen, 1994) and informative feedback (Shneiderman et al., 2016).
- **Tasks integrated into the conversation (C2).** A GitLab commit or issue shows up in the group chat, and a task assigned in chat updates GitLab, because the group "communicated more on Discord rather than GitLab itself". This follows flexibility and efficiency of use (Nielsen, 1994) and reduces short-term memory load (Shneiderman et al., 2016).
- **Meeting scheduling with RSVPs (C3),** with a prompt to propose another time when someone cannot attend. This addresses meetings where people do not show up and give no alternative, and follows visibility of system status (Nielsen, 1994) and informative feedback (Shneiderman et al., 2016).
- **A single submission step (C4)** that does not require collating files from several platforms, with clear confirmation of what has been sent. Cara pasted a YouTube link into GitLab and gathered Miro and Godot files by hand. This follows design closure (Shneiderman et al., 2016) and visibility of system status (Nielsen, 1994).
- **Help requests from inside the system (C5),** linked to the evidence, such as commit history for a non-contributor or code snippets for a bug. Her group could have complained about a teammate but did not, so staff should be easy to contact. This follows error prevention (Nielsen, 1994).

Pain Points:

- Group setup is inconsistent: finding and creating a group is different for every project, and the group page, members and their details were hard to find (from interview)
- A teammate went missing and the group only found out through missing commits, so the rest picked up the slack (from interview)
- Meetings were skipped with no alternative time offered (from interview)
- Tasks live in GitLab issues while the discussion of who does what happens on Discord (from interview)
- Most workflow tools sit outside university; only GitLab is provided (from interview)
- Tools failed at a crucial deadline when students from several courses submitted at once (from interview)
- Current tools overcomplicate tasks (from interview)
- Scattered tools were the most common group-work complaint: 8 of 10 respondents (from survey)

Personality Traits:

- Organised early: joins the group Discord as soon as a project starts
- Dependable: picks up a missing teammate's work instead of leaving it unfinished
- Comfortable with developer tooling (GitLab, Miro, video creation)
- Stays informed through Discord and weekly in-person meetings, and finds it easy to keep on top of a project
- Tolerant of many tools being required, but would welcome integration between them
- Rarely needs tutor or lecturer help in group work

References

Nielsen, J. (1994). 10 Usability Heuristics for User Interface Design.

Shneiderman, B., Plaisant, C., Cohen, M., Jacobs, S., & Elmqvist, N. (2016). Designing the User Interface: Strategies for Effective Human-Computer Interaction